Introduction to the Sciences of Hadith

How reports about the Prophet were collected and verified

Maktaba — Islamic Digital Library · Sample Edition.
This booklet is an original short text produced as sample content for the library.

What a hadith is

A hadith is a report of something the Prophet Muhammad said, did, or approved. Because these reports shape Muslim practice and belief, early scholars developed an elaborate discipline for collecting, testing, and classifying them — known as the sciences of hadith (ulum al-hadith).

Isnad and matn

Every hadith has two parts. The **matn** is the content — the actual statement or event. The **isnad** is the chain of people who transmitted the report, one from another, back to a companion of the Prophet.

The isnad made transmission accountable. Critics examined each person in the chain: their integrity, their reliability as narrators, whether they could have met the person they narrate from, and whether their reports were consistent. This method, formalised within the first Islamic centuries, is among the earliest systematic source-criticism traditions in world literature.

Classifications of strength

Sahih (sound): a continuous chain of upright, precise narrators, free of irregularity and hidden defect. **Hasan** (good): meeting similar conditions, with slightly less precision in the narrators' retentiveness. **Da'if** (weak): failing one or more conditions — a broken chain, a narrator of questioned reliability, a contradiction of stronger reports, or a hidden defect discovered by specialists.

Weak reports are not all the same; specialists describe dozens of specific defects. Collections devoted to identifying them — such as those of al-Daraqutni and later Ibn al-Jawzi — show how seriously scholars treated the boundary between reliable and unreliable material.

The great collections

The six collections often called the Kutub al-Sittah — of al-Bukhari, Muslim, Abu Dawud, al-Tirmidhi, al-Nasa'i, and Ibn Majah — became the most widely studied hadith books in the Sunni world. Al-Bukhari's and Muslim's collections (the two Sahihs) are treated with particular care for their authors' strict selection criteria.

Hadith scholarship never stopped at compilation. Commentaries, biographical dictionaries of narrators (rijal), and abridgements continued to be written for over a thousand years, and continue today.

A note for readers

Popular books sometimes quote reports without their classifications. Readers who want to rely on a hadith for practice are usually best served by checking how specialist works classified it, or by asking a qualified teacher.

— End of the booklet —